

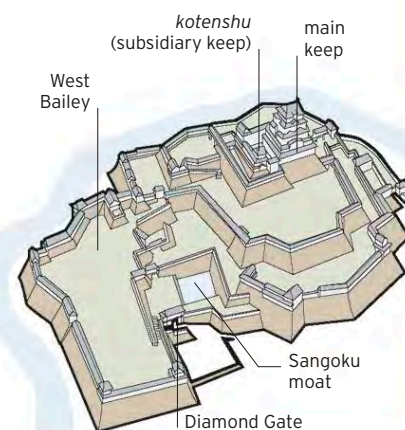
Himeji Castle

A masterpiece of wood-and-stone construction and one of Japan's last surviving feudal castles from the 16th and 17th centuries



THE NAWABARI OF HIMEJI

Many warlords believed that a castle's *nawabari*—its layout and defensive system—determined its fate. As this plan shows, Himeji Castle had a complex *nawabari* design with a three-layer spiral defense system. This created a series of descents and switchbacks to bewilder enemies and conceal the keep's entrance.



Known to many as White Egret Castle or White Heron Castle because it is said to resemble a bird taking flight, Himeji Castle was built by Ikeda Terumasa in 1601–1609. Ikeda was appointed governor of the western provinces by Tokugawa Ieyasu (whose dynasty ruled as Shoguns over Japan until the late 19th century), and his castle was part of the Shogun's peacekeeping plan to build one castle per province.

Designed for defense

Ikeda Terumasa replaced the existing three-story keep with a five-story castle that in fact hides six floors and a basement (see pp.294–295). He added three further keeps, linked by two-story covered corridors in a formation known as *renritsu tenshu*

(“connected towers”). There was only one access point to the keeps, and the outward-facing walls of the complex were protected with gun and arrow ports and stone drop windows (wooden structures with openings at the bottom through which rocks could be thrown). The castle was surrounded by a spiral-shaped moat, within which were a series of fortified gateways, and a labyrinth of courtyards and steep passageways designed to confuse attackers. An almost impregnable castle, its tiers of roofs and decorative gables were also a beautiful expression of traditional Japanese style. The castle somehow survived the extensive Allied bombing of Japan in World War II, becoming one of Japan's National Treasures in 1931 and one of the country's first two UNESCO World Heritage Sites in 1993.

The **complex defenses** of Himeji were **never tested**, as the castle was **never attacked**

▽ IMPENETRABLE BEAUTY

The graceful eaves, elegant multiple-tiered roofs, and clean white walls of the five-story main keep at Himeji make it a prototypical example of Japanese architecture of the 17th century. Stone drop windows can be seen around the lowest story.

